Well before a number of French and other officers were inducted into the Sikh army to train and organize this force on the lines of contemporary European armies, Captain A.H. Bingley wrote in 1818 that Ranjit Singh's 'battalions were a formidable body of troops, well disciplined and steady. Their endurance was remarkable and it was not unusual for whole regiments to make 30-mile marches often for days at a time'.[6] The courage and resilience of Sikh soldiers was underlined when twenty-one of them, from a single unit (the 36th Sikhs) and in a single day, fought to the last and were posthumously given the highest military decoration – Member of the British Empire (MBE) – that Britain could bestow on soldiers of the Indian Army. This action took place on 12 September 1897 at Saragarhi in North West Frontier Province, and is acknowledged as a feat of gallantry and sacrifice unsurpassed in the annals of military history.

The 'warrior' in my psyche has a lot to do with the Sikh history, tradition and culture. In one of my fantasies, I see myself as a 'Sikh warrior' of yore, on a mission to wreak havoc against the savage and cruel invaders who came frequently from the northwest frontiers of Hindustan, and whose primary objectives were conquest, pillage, abduction, rape and plunder. Our band of warriors has pledged to fight for the defence of the dharma and our lands, and save our countrymen from slavery and tyranny of the conquering forces. With revenge on our faces, we would swoop down on the camps or caravans of the returning alien forces, and play 'merry hell' with them. Much like the nineteenth century Sikh cavalryman described brilliantly by Major General Sir George Younghusband in Philip Mason's book, *A Matter of Honour*, 'Some of our men lost their turbans … A Sikh, with hair long as a woman's streaming in the wind, bending low and hard forward, yelling like a fiend and bringing his curved sword down on all and sundry, with a soft whistling drawing cut, is like a demon of dark dreams. There was no mercy for those fleeing enemies than they would have shown themselves.'[7]

We would rescue many hostages and prisoners and recover as much of the ill-gotten booty as possible. In particular, we would endeavour to rescue the women and children who would have